fought alongside the Afghan Taliban. There were approximately 6,000 members in this brigade. The international brigade comprised up to one-third of the Taliban forces. Al Qaeda used the basic military training at the camps to select promising individuals for advanced training in establishing cells and combat.

After 2001, the strength of Al Qaeda was estimated to have been depleted from 3,000–4,000 to a few hundred people (*Studies in Conflict & Terrorism*, 2008). In Pakistan, top Al Qaeda leaders, including Osama bin Laden, had been neutralised, leaving only less than 100 core group members of Al Qaeda in FATA.[15] Al Qaeda struggled to replenish its strength from within Pakistan, as it did not have a system and structure to recruit Pakistanis. It relied on groups based in Pakistan to recruit helpers and facilitators to continue their activities within Pakistan (Fair, 2009). However, its asymmetrical system to run a loose federation worked well as other similar groups helped increase its strength (*Rodrigues & Stichting*, 2010). The spokesperson of Al Qaeda in Pakistan was an American, Adam Yahiye Gadahn, alias Adam Pearlman, from a well-known family in California. Besides Uzbeks, Chechens, Turks, Afghanis and so on, TTP was the largest and fiercest group raised by it in FATA and Swat.

Al Qaeda – TTP nexus, activities and concerns

The fundamental reason for the origin of Al Qaeda was disenchantment of its leaders with the systems of their Arab homelands, for instance, mostly Saudi Arabia and Egypt. Later, America became its focus due to its influence on the leaders and systems of these homelands. Initially, Pakistan was not a target of Al Qaeda. In 2002, the army operations against them in FATA made them turn against General Musharraf. However, Pakistan, as a country, was still not the target, but there seemed to be no love lost for Pakistan as was evident from its policies and actions aimed against its interests.

However, Al Qaeda wanted to avail the FATA safe haven to carry on its agenda unhindered and, of course, without clashing with the Pakistan Army and security agencies. For this purpose, another 'force' was needed that could engage the Pakistan government and army so that Al Qaeda could focus on the US and the rest on its list. Axiomatically, the scattered tribesmen, mostly with jihadi background, who were already hosting them, were the most suitable to fit in this policy. Thus, the TTP emerged as the leading group of